Rate wars apart, the competition impacted the passengers in other ways as well. The experience of Dr T.S.S. Rajan, who later became an important Congress leader, offers a peep into this. Sometime in 1907, on his maiden voyage to London to pursue higher education in Britain—where he would form friendships with V.V.S. Aiyar and V.D. Savarkar and get entangled in the assassination of Sir Curzon-Wyllie, aide-de-camp to the secretary of state for India—Rajan arrived at Tuticorin. In his hand was a ticket from Colombo to London which he had bought through Thomas Cook at Rangoon where he had been based earlier. His politically-minded friends had booked him on the Swadeshi steamer. This short voyage to Colombo caused considerable inconvenience if not actual hardship. Firstly, the BI steamer left Tuticorin's shores promptly at 6 p.m. Informed that the Swadeshi steamer too would lift anchor at the same time, Rajan boarded—probably the *Lawoe*—at 5 p.m. but there was no sign of it setting sail until midnight. Cargo was loaded through the evening even as he watched from the deck. When a hungry Rajan wanted a bite, he was asked why he required a meal for an overnight voyage. More inconveniences were in store at Colombo. Rajan had wired Thomas Cook of his arrival at Colombo but there was no one to receive him and his considerable baggage. It transpired that—in evident solidarity with their British compatriots—Thomas Cook did not extend this privilege to passengers arriving by the Swadeshi steamer.[142]

Collision

There were other hitches as well. It seems that the *Lawoe* was jinxed from the beginning. If it took months to arrive in India after its purchase, soon it was involved in a collision with a cargo boat killing two men and a boy. Following this, a court of inquiry was constituted under the Merchant Shipping Act of 1883.[143] F.A. Coleridge, the district collector of Tirunelveli, Lieutenant W.L. Kelly, port officer, Tuticorin and D. Miller, a merchant of Tuticorin sat in court.[144]